

The Ideological Difference Between Eastern & Western Videogames and Its Consequences

Introduction

This essay argues the principal reason for design differences between Eastern and Western videogames is not socioeconomic factors¹, but ideology; ergo they are not malleable but cultural, recommending rejection of global monoculture². Comparison begins with distinction between American and Japanese roleplaying games (RPGs), identifying also how perceived differences manifest within Europe, or China and Korea (referred to as PRC for mainland China and ROK for South Korea where relevant), and across genres.

Differences

There is existing classification of JRPGs (Japanese RPGs) against WRPGs (Western RPGs). WRPGs originate³ with American *Ultima* (Origin Systems, 1981) and *Wizardry* (Sir-Tech, 1981), the latter inspiring the dungeon-crawler genre; the first JRPG,

¹ This is the dominant position of literature, e.g. in Navarro-Remesal & Loriguillo-López (2015).

² “West” and “East” mean hereinafter cultures shaped by Liberalism and Individualism, and Confucianism and Collectivism, respectively. “Liberalism”, as far as it is used within this essay, refers to Classical (“English”) Liberalism, rather than its modern (chiefly American) usage that refers particularly to left-wing “progressive” thought.

³ The origins of WRPGs can be traced further back, to tabletop RPGs, and then further to seminal Western fantasy literature (e.g. *The Lord of the Rings* (Tolkien, 1954-5)) that continue to influence WRPGs and JRPGs today (Killingsworth, 2022).

Dragon Quest (Chunsoft, 1986), was inspired by both — particularly *Wizardry* — focussing on character, simplifying mechanics, and streamlining progression for console-based audiences borne from Nintendo Famicom⁴ fans rather than computer hobbyists (Kohler, 2004).

Evolution from *Dragon Quest* explains *genre* distinction (between JRPG and WRPG), not the design of Eastern RPGs generally, which continue borrowing from Western rather than domestic lineage: Japanese *King's Field* (FromSoftware, 1994) hearkens *Wizardry*, and *Elden Ring* (FromSoftware, 2022) Western open-world RPGs (Killingsworth). Hutchinson (2019) draws more consistent design distinctions: all RPGs intend players' immersion, JRPGs through characterisation and narrative (e.g. *Final Fantasy*, Square, 1987-present), WRPGs through worldbuilding and agency (e.g. *The Elder Scrolls*, Bethesda, 1994-present). Japanese *Shenmue* (AM2, 1999) and British *Grand Theft Auto: San Andreas* (Rockstar, 2004) stray from JRPG and WRPG traditions, aiming at immersive cities. *Shenmue*'s Yokosuka is small but believable for its detail and character interactions; *San Andreas* is immersive for its size and explorative freedom. Polish *The Witcher 3* (CD Projekt, 2015), while having stronger narrative and characterisation than most WRPGs, offers a richer world with more side-content than Japanese *NieR:Automata* (PlatinumGames, 2017).

There still appear exceptions. Within online RPGs, Korean *Black Desert* (Pearl Abyss, 2015) focusses player-expression more than American *The Elder Scrolls Online* (ZeniMax, 2014), which has stronger narratives. Hutchinson notes JRPGs reward perseverance, even through repetition. This can be extended to other East Asian

⁴ The Nintendo Entertainment System (NES) in the West, known as the Family Computer (*famirī konpyūta* / ファミリーコンピュータ) in Japan.

games: *Black Desert* features more “grinding”⁵ than *The Elder Scrolls Online*, which is less restrictive regarding what the player can access relative to time investment. Santos (2015) extends this observation to the hack-and-slash genre⁶, observing Western games aim at empowerment, while such must be earned in Eastern games. *Elden Ring*, while discouraging “grinding”, similarly restricts progression till sufficient demonstration of skill and diligence.

Hutchinson explores how characterisation impacts further aspects of games⁷.

Amnesiac or outsider protagonists are common across RPGs: in JRPGs, usually as a plot-point, whereby learning about their past, developing the story, explaining diegetic hierarchies⁸; in WRPGs as contrivance enabling backstory-imagining for avatars⁹. Either way it is conducive to worldbuilding: in JRPGs insofar as necessary for story and character dynamics, whereas worldbuilding is focal to WRPGs¹⁰.

Characters in JRPGs experience growth at significant points, moreover the whole story climaxes towards the end; WRPGs focus on world- over character-building, relying on the gestalt of the game-world’s minutiae rather than narrative. There are WRPGs featuring parties of characters, such as Canadian *Baldur’s Gate* (BioWare, 1998), but members are recruited foremost to benefit gameplay rather than story.

⁵ This is the practice common of particularly JRPGs where progression is facilitated by voluntary repetition of mundane tasks.

⁶ Santos contrasts how the player is challenged in Japanese *Bayonetta* (PlatinumGames, 2009) and American *God of War* (Santa Monica Studio, 2005).

⁷ Hutchinson explores how character relates also to theming in JRPGs, which often tell stories related to difficult relationships with parents, relating to recent changes in familial relationships that contrast with traditions. Even in *Elden Ring*, director Miyazaki admits early story concepts centred “parent-and-child relationships” (quoted in Killingsworth).

⁸ E.g. Japanese *Final Fantasy X* (Square, 2001) and *Persona 5* (Atlus, 2016). Moreover hierarchy is relevant in Eastern culture, as will be explored later.

⁹ E.g. American *The Elder Scrolls III: Morrowind* (Bethesda Game Studios, 2002) and Canadian *Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic* (BioWare, 2003).

¹⁰ Exceptions undoubtedly exist, however even in games like *Elden Ring* with strong worldbuilding, the worldbuilding is not focal, but an optional part of the experience.

Moreover *Black Desert* and *Elden Ring*, while having extensive lore, relegate worldbuilding to a secondary part of the experience.

Games such as *Elden Ring* that eschew superficial Japanese character are termed *mukokuseki*¹¹, i.e. non-cultural. Supposedly, the purpose is to make games globally-marketable (Grau, 2019); withal global successes of games forefronting Japanese culture supposedly owe to the inverse: self-Orientalism (Hutchinson). *Katamari Damacy* (Namco, 2004) allegedly flaunts Japaneseness (Hutchinson; Grau), humouring Western perceptions of Japanese weirdness (Hutchinson; Bramwell, 2006). However, O'Hagan (2009) correctly identifies culture is so embedded within videogames that localisation cannot undo it, and cultural differences manifest within all aspects of the game, including the mechanics; even with intentional *mukokuseki* applied, games are still Foucauldian products of their environment. O'Hagan gives the example of *Ico* (Sony, 2005), which despite a Western-looking environment and characters not distinctly Japanese speaking in a fictional language, is unmistakably Japanese with deliberate camera-angles favouring design over agency — a feature of Eastern games explained in the next section.

Mukokuseki exposes discrepancy between how games' presentation and behaviour, this being significant for confirming distinction between Eastern and Western games. While Hutchinson observes Japanese RPGs'¹² focus on characterisation, *The Witcher 3* contextualises the player's purpose within Geralt and Ciri's relationship as does Japanese *Shadow of the Colossus* (Sony, 2005) between Wander and Mono. In

¹¹ Within this context, the term was applied by Iwabuchi (2002), who translated it as “odourless”: i.e. lacking distinct cultural elements, instead being culturally bland or basic, and so equally accessible to foreign audiences. The word itself, 無国籍, translates literally to “statelessness”, or “lacking in membership to a particular country”.

¹² I shall use “Japanese RPG” where I am referring literally to an RPG developed in Japan, as opposed to a game that specifically adopts the normative characteristics of the JRPG as a genre.

the former, when immersed in gameplay, the player's focus is gaining strength and exploring, as traditional of WRPGs; the latter has no additional feature of the game motivating the player beyond desire to help Mono. Similarly, the barrenness of *Shadow of the Colossus*' world fosters a closer relationship between Wander and his steed Agro than *Witcher 3*'s bustling world permitting fast-travel fosters between Geralt and Roach, despite Geralt's horse being more directly characterised¹³. Moreover, the expressive characters of American *Uncharted 4* (Naughty Dog, 2016) operate as background elements sometimes making platforming more interesting, while *Ico*'s Yorda is relevant to all gameplay. With superficial context stripped away, Eastern or Western characteristics surface.

Ideology

Western Individualist and Eastern Collectivist social structures create independent and interdependent¹⁴ conceptions of "self". Independence favours autonomy; interdependence other-focussed emotions and co-dependence (Markus & Kitayama, 1991). Western and Eastern philosophy draw upon, then perpetuate, ideological practice: Confucianism fosters social-harmony, with its principal virtue *rén*¹⁵, then echoed in Japanese *wa*¹⁶ (ibid.); Liberalism, meanwhile, prioritises individual

¹³ Horse-riding is sometimes necessary within quests, and also Roach can be enhanced with new equipment. But despite Geralt also being shown to have a close connexion with his horse, the relatively low utility of Roach throughout gameplay fosters no such connexion between Roach and the player.

¹⁴ That is, generally-speaking, Westerners seek validation from within, and East-Asians from others (Markus & Kitayama). The West encourages realisation of individual potential while East-Asian concepts of personhood manifest in relation to others, with behaviour always contextual (ibid.). Markus and Kitayama contrast Chinese conception of the individual as an incomplete part of a social whole with Cartesian dualism that separates the self from the material world (Descartes, 2008[1641]).

¹⁵ (仁), i.e. harmonious behaviour. Referred to as *jen* in Markus & Kitayama, using the older Wade-Giles romanisation.

¹⁶ (和), i.e. interpersonal harmony.

freedoms, and battles to justify authority as conducive to liberty (Hobbes, 1993[1651]; Locke, 1993[1689]). This contrasts with Eastern favourability for rigid hierarchical structure and strong authority conducive to harmony (Grayling, 2019).

Given conceptions of “self” drive cognition, emotions, and motivations (Markus & Kitayama), it would seem they affect videogame design. However, most existing literature justifies differences as consequences of incidental socioeconomic conditions. Picard (2013) denies an essential aspect to Japanese games: they are entirely products of their market. The Japanese games industry emerged in the arcades, owing to a large existing entertainment sector, then expanding into homes via consoles through the success of the Famicom (ibid.). By contrast, the West ushered gaming through a predominantly PC market because computer hobbyists, becoming independent developers, led the industry¹⁷. Hutchinson ventures slightly further, exploring influences of geopolitics, history, national identity, and familial relations within Japanese games, but in a contemporary and mutable framing. The limitation of these views is, as identified, the persistence of certain characteristics across East Asia, where contemporary social issues and politics, and the platforms on which games are played¹⁸, differ.

Furthermore, the market is not incidental: console-gaming’s dominance in Japan, and by extension dominant design features in the industry, were ideologically influenced. The popularity of “game-centres”¹⁹, as with computer cafés across East Asia, indicate a culture separating leisure and home-life. Nintendo broke through by marketing its “Family Computer” as congenial to the household, with separate games

¹⁷ Picard suggests a reason for Japan being slower to cultivate a large PC market is because displaying Japanese and Chinese characters required special software and machines.

¹⁸ Chinese games resemble Japanese despite targeting PC and mobile platforms; PRC enforced a ban on consoles between 2000 and 2015. ROK, too, has a larger PC market than Japan.

¹⁹ (*gēmu sentā* / ゲームセンター) i.e. Japanese video or amusement arcade.

targeting adults and children. That it was marketed as “Nintendo Entertainment System” in the West is telling of ideological factors: there it was not considered important to market it for family, and “Computer” would connote creative programmability common of computers in the West but not East. Moreover, it was the first home system to profit mainly from games, which paired with the restriction against programmability moved the Japanese industry towards quality, familiarity, and marketability, with games now being higher quality, ports of recognisable arcade games, or using familiar licenses (ibid.). Not disregarding Japanese “indie” games, the West’s games industry ostensibly owes more to experimentation, modification, and independent projects²⁰.

Ideology’s practice in the workplace also influences the industry. Following *wa*, Japanese are often hired from school (Winterhalter, 2007) and employed for life, fostering workplace harmony (Moriguchi & Ono, 2004). Consequently, Japanese games companies tend towards perfection rather than innovation. Moreover, individuals are not generally rewarded, but departments (Winterhalter). This practice is echoed in the aforementioned championing of perseverance in Japanese games, and selfless motivations. Zagal (2014) notes aspiring game-designers in Japan usually have a clear idea of the games they want to make based on games they already admire, rarely seeking to venture beyond what they are comfortable with. Though this might not be unique to Japan (Zagal notes it in USA), it supports that if

²⁰ For example, in the evolution of the first-person shooter genre through iterative modification (e.g. *DOOM* (id Software, 1993) to *Quake* (id Software, 1996) to *Half Life* (Valve, 1998) to *Counter Strike* (Valve, 2000), and the longevity of *The Elder Scrolls* titles through player modifications. Also, with major, mainstream independent games e.g. *Minecraft* (Markus Persson, 2011), while Japanese independent games are generally smaller in scope (primarily products of RPG-Maker, or visual novels), sustaining more niche relevance towards exclusively other independent games, e.g. *Yume Nikki* (Kikiyama, 2004).

ideology can provoke differences in game design initially, those features will perpetually become more prominent.

Having explored how Eastern standards of interpersonal relations and harmony affect the industry as a whole, let us identify how they affect games' design. Artistic objects are products of designers' ways of thinking (Hutchinson), and one component of "harmony" is conformity: Japanese's propensity to internalise emotions invites emotionally-complex characters in videogames, through whom emotion can be acknowledged (Kalata, 2007), e.g. in *Persona* (1996-present). Interdependence also manifests in how Eastern games centralise relationships for motivation: how characters motivate the protagonist (Hutchinson) but also how the player is motivated, as explored earlier in *Shadow of the Colossus*. Hierarchy, as constructive to harmony, is intrinsic to Eastern games. Japanese hierarchies are revealed in speech, and this is present in dialogue nuances in JRPGs, conducive to worldbuilding and character-personality (Hutchinson), beneficial to constructing sympathetic and believable characters relevant to plot and gameplay. Moreover, interdependence enforces comparative manifestation of personhood relative to others (Markus & Kitayama) — expressed within Chinese *Genshin Impact*'s (miHoYo, 2020) *gacha*²¹ mechanics (Adams, 2022), which disperse the self amongst predetermined characters, enabling the player comfortable entry to a pre-ordered system rather than being required to define one from chaos (ibid.): Confucian thought believes the natural state to be good, discouraging interference (Grayling). Meanwhile, Western favourability for freedom rationalises the importance of player-autonomy and self-expression in Western games, whereas Eastern games more

²¹ *Gacha* games derive their name from *gachapon* (ガチャポン), i.e. Japanese capsule vending machines, sharing the mechanic of randomised rewards, usually operating as live-service. *Genshin Impact* is Chinese, not Japanese, but the popular terminology is ubiquitous.

greatly subject the player to the designer's particular vision (Clarendon, Red Fly Studios, cited in Kalata), as identified in *Ico* — in a sense giving the designer authority over the player, rather than giving the player authority over the game.

The “perseverance” characteristic identified earlier of Eastern games is connected to multiple cultural ideas. Hutchinson associates disciplined practice fostered by Japanese *Street Fighter* (Capcom, 1987-present) to that of traditional Japanese martial-arts training. Kalata contrasts American *SimCity* (Maxis, 1989) and Japanese *Harvest Moon* (Amccus, 1996), noting the Western audience enjoy control, and the Japanese nurture, identifying this with agrarian tradition. Agrarianism relates also to Individualist and Collectivist divergence, according to wheat-farming benefiting from ingenuity and technological advancement more than rice-farming, which required greater interdependence and coordination (Talhelm, 2022).

Ramifications

Given ideological basis for differences in design, it follows these are not incidental nor intentional, thus not arbitrary nor mutable, but deeply cultural. Where former analysis encourages culturalisation towards global monoculture, this new framing encourages cultural preservation beneficial to intransigence between East and West, and their individual merits.

Invocation of *mukokuseki* is a detriment for applying intentionality to games' cultural quality, divisively defining games as either *mukokuseki* or “self-Orientalising”. The former ignores idiosyncrasies of Japanese games; the latter mandates a Western framing of Japanese culture from which accurate portrayal will be exotic. Consequently, the presentation of Japanese games is viewed as an

intentional projection unto the West, rather than inherent. Theories drawing on *mukokuseki* consider games' presentation deliberately bland or exoticised for global markets, ignoring earnest presentation of culture, fallaciously considering all expression of culture intentional rather than emergent, furthermore rendering normative Western culture. This has negatively affected analysis of Eastern games. Fundamentally, the Orient is exotic to Western eyes, and vice-versa; game-developers from both hemispheres have different cultural and ideological backgrounds. *Persona 5* was the first *Persona* game to be principally set in a real Japanese location²² and forefronts Japanese culture incredibly honestly²³, since becoming the most successful entry in the series globally, prompting multiple spin-off titles, so calling *mukokuseki*'s legitimacy into question. *Mukokuseki* also assumes that Japanese games are successful globally because of the absence of certain qualities, rather than qualities' presence; analysis would suggest the most globally popular Japanese games are popular because of their excellent design that excels them beyond most Western games, rather than the absence of self-evidently "Japanese" characteristics.

Mukokuseki does exist insofar as it affects the practices of a minority of Japanese companies, such as Kojima Productions, intentionally moving towards the global market (Consalvo, 2009). Grau notes *Metal Gear Solid 4* (Kojima Productions, 2008) as the exemplification of *mukokuseki*, claiming its popularity owes to its recognition of contemporary issues; however these are notably American in focus²⁴,

²² *Persona 5* is set in Tokyo and features many of the city's districts as playable locations and makes prominent landmarks such as the Tokyo Tower. Prior *Persona* games were set in fictional Japanese towns.

²³ *Persona 5* is rich with Japanese culture, but it not exoticised, its Tokyo being authentically cosmopolitan, having an American amongst the main cast, and tackling difficult social topics relevant to Japan; nor is it culturalised, as it does not conform to Western social standards or political-correctness.

²⁴ For example, military interventionism (Hutchinson).

aligning with criticism that *mukokuseki* falls into American globalism. The game was indeed more popular in the USA and Britain than Japan. *Mukokuseki* as in *Metal Gear Solid 4* also exposes that Japan views the West as a homogeneity; smoothing over cultural and traditional discrepancies existent in the West or East enables a globalist monoculture dictated by the dominant culture, in this case the USA.

O'Hagan believes awareness of cultural difference to benefit cross-cultural design, where games are designed for a global audience; I believe in the opposite approach. Recognition of the pervasiveness of cultural ideology within a product should not encourage that they are purged; a game made to resonate with a culturally synonymous domestic audience should not be compromised in its vision to appeal to outsiders – who should themselves adapt if wishing to appreciate cultural media. That games are fundamentally approached differently by Eastern and Western players discourages the normalisation of a single mode. Keever (2022) identifies that ideological structures perpetually enforce that same ideology in their products, so games are inherently ideological. Playing involves interaction with that ideology, so ideologically foreign players face conflict. Tripathy (2023) considers “proper” engagement with the freedom offered by Western game-worlds to demand Liberal rationality; Harrington and Zhang (2022) observe that Chinese players manifested a collective goal of their own, in the absence of one, within American *H1Z1* (Daybreak Company, 2018), according to “naturalised” moral imperative towards patriotism²⁵. Likewise, Western standards explain comparative discomfort towards grinding and

²⁵ This was a widespread incident where Chinese players would identify one another by wearing red shirts, then collaborate despite the 4-player limit to team sizes, so invariably winning the game through cheating.

gacha mechanics²⁶. Nevertheless, the ability of cultures to design congruently with their ideology is positive, as is global exposure to these cultural products.

The problem is that Western egalitarianism believes that everything should be for everyone. O'Hagan explores *Ico*'s Japanese essence with a view to culturalising it — making it palatable — for a global audience. But even as a Japanese game, *Ico* was unconventional; features O'Hagan identified were *not* Japanese idiosyncrasies but products of careful, intentional design. Western egalitarianism accepts differences in design insofar as they are palatably and immediately identifiable as exotic, or fit within a monocultural system. O'Hagan praises *Ico*'s non-verbal storytelling because it fits into a monocultural order without language barriers, but all other features are considered expendable. Non-verbal storytelling cannot be normalised within Japanese games, which rely upon nuances in dialogue that do not exist in English to establish hierarchies and reveal personalities (Hutchinson): cultural homogeneity prevents that acute resonance of games intended for a specific culture.

Another way in which this Western egalitarian imposition manifests is identity-politics. Hutchinson encourages the portrayal of minority groups in Japan, suggesting this would likely need to be initiated from an outside perspective, as occurred with *Grand Theft Auto: San Andreas*. Ultimately this did happen in Canadian *Assassins Creed Shadows* (Ubisoft, 2025), and predictably, it had disastrous consequences. In both cases, from an outside, self-righteous, and unknowledgeable position, history was rewritten, literally or by association, in such a

²⁶ Western players find a dissonance between *Genshin Impact*'s presentation as an RPG and its live-service mechanics, as the player is not rewarded for engaging with the RPG world and mechanics, but rather the *gacha* mechanics — requiring more monetary or time investment — as evidenced by Messner's (2020) review. However, this is often associated with it being a free-to-play game, rather than for cultural factors (Notis, 2020; Kemps, 2020).

way that was harmful or insensitive²⁷. Secondly, the West will impose its anti-Nationalism upon politically congruous Eastern countries such as Japan, as evidenced in Hutchinson's criticism of the "Japanese privilege" in *Street Fighter*: that Japanese Ryu is presented as the standard character, and other cultures presented exotically.

Another reason for discouragement of culturalisation is games' status as invaluable expressions of culture. Beadle (2022) examines how gamification intensifies religious tradition in Taiwanese horror games; the flow-state afforded by excellent games enables effective absorption of information through habituation (ibid.; Jacobs, 2020). Hutchinson notes how gamification is conducive to ideological messaging: *Katamari Damacy*'s gameplay loop of interaction with nostalgic Japanese objects evokes sentimentality²⁸ of the *furusato*²⁹. She notes gameplay is more important than narrative ideologically, as it is effective from beginning till end.

Criticism of culturalisation should not be construed as advocacy of insularity, noting Wirman (2015) boldly suggests PRC's lifting of the console-ban is Westernisation; openness to other media is not destructive to one's own culture. Wirman further criticises British media for even covering PRC's games industry and daring to judge it. However awareness of other practices can occur without enforcement of monoculture, and can progress industries in the case of enabling PRC to become more

²⁷ In summary, *San Andreas* is the first *Grand Theft Auto* with a Black protagonist, and uses this to "dispel" racial stereotypes, instead endorsing the stereotype that American police are racist, which is especially harmful given the association with the LA riots that Dyer-Witherford and Peuter (2009) draw, giving an incomplete and biased perspective of events: such is easy from the perspective of those who did not witness them (i.e. the British development studio), and want to take moral high-ground. *Assassins Creed Shadows* triggered many controversies, most egregious being by enabling the player to desecrate a real shrine receiving formal complaint (Takahashi, 2025). There were also other cultural insensitivities, not least that the protagonist of the only *Assassins Creed* game set in Japan features an African of dubious historical authenticity killing Japanese people. Satisfying Western identity politics was clearly more important than gratifying the Japanese audience.

²⁸ Grau similarly notes, in relation to *Katamari Damacy*, that games are capable of strengthening culture through practical repetition.

²⁹ (故郷), meaning "hometown".

open: Wirman notes British coverage of the Chinese games-industry becoming more positive as PRC became less restrictive. Requiring that Western countries be ambivalent to the practices of the East is, itself, a rejection of cultural values, and a suggestion that ideology is ultimately meaningless. Asking, as Wirman does, that either East or West not construct an Other in opposition to the Self, is effectively a rejection of Self, enabling homogenisation. Similarly, Santos acknowledges cross-influence of Eastern and Western games towards a globalised industry — which is fine provided the globalised industry is diverse rather than monocultural.

Whilst Western games' Liberalism encounters issues, so too do Eastern games' Collectivism. Adams observes of *gacha* games utilisation of *gacha* labour towards emotional investment in digital characters (facilitated by interdependent ideology), enabling the construction of a “meta-person” comprised of the individual and their character. Players continue to identify with their character outside of the game, in other digital settings and the real-world. Adams forebodingly sees this as conducive to the establishment of unity between the corporeal and digital-selves, realising a neo-Socialist metaverse enforced by digital ID. Moreover the *gacha* rewards system is Socialist, as players pay *into* the system with time and money; the game's morality is not within the world or narrative, but the time investment towards work (ibid.).

Tripathy also suggests flow-states are conducive to malleability to authority, claiming this is qualitative of “data-colonialism” but it can more accurately be applied to the greater flow-states established by Eastern games, and neo-Socialism. Tripathy suggests neoliberalism is anti-democratic in that game rules are constructed by the game company in a “dictatorial fashion” rather than by a “collective body”, though said collective-body would surely be an authoritarian state like PRC that already has insidious reach over the Chinese games industry. “Agency” in games is compelled by

ideological forces (Keever), as can be seen in how Liberally-encoded games encourage self-expression, even outside of Liberal society, which is to their merit. In *Frostpunk* (11 Bit Studios, 2018), players' benevolent rule is as important as society's survival³⁰; Chinese players accused it of Liberal³¹ moral-superiority, so collectively establishing a Socialist objective within the game (Harrington & Zhang). Confucianism is more inclined to authority being good in-itself, and judged by its efficacy rather than benevolence (Grayling). Conversely, Japanese *Animal Crossing: New Horizons* (Nintendo, 2020) was removed from the PRC marketplace after means of expression within the game were used for pro-Democracy protest (Davidson, 2020). The British government, too, attempted enforcement of anti-Liberal submissive mindset by funding *Pathways* (2025) — a game aimed at silencing legitimate protest with visual-novel framing giving the illusion of liberal choice. Dissonance with the target audience's ideology similarly led to subversion, with players purposefully taking the “bad” narrative route and adopting the “antagonist” as an icon for the online-Right. The significance of ideology in videogames, when enabled, manifest in conflict that can challenge and synthesise or strengthen points-of-view.

Conclusion

Ideology's significance in game-design discourages culturalisation appealing to the common denominator and eroding distinct identities, in favour of resonance with a target audience. Players should adapt to the games they consume, rather than vice-

³⁰ *Frostpunk* is a Polish city-building survival game where the goal is firstly the survival of the people, and secondly balancing this with morals — i.e. maintaining people's liberties.

³¹ The term used was *baizuo* (白左), lit. “White Left”.

versa. Nevertheless, free interaction and dialogue between cultures should be encouraged for the progress of the industry.

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Ludography

This section has been divided between Eastern (Chinese, Japanese, Korean) and Western (North American & European) games for the benefit of comparison within the text.

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